

The Research Gap Framework

A Practical Workbook to Identify Publishable Research Gaps

by Dr Sakshi Kathuria | @sakshi_kathuria271

“A great paper doesn’t begin with a methodology. It begins with a question that genuinely deserves to be answered.”

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What Is a Research Gap?

THE MYTH	One of the biggest misconceptions among PhD scholars is believing a research gap is simply an unexplored topic. It isn't.
THE DEFINITION	A research gap is a meaningful limitation, inconsistency, unanswered question, or opportunity within existing literature that justifies why another study is needed.
THE DISTINCTION	A research topic tells us what you are studying. A research gap explains why your study needs to exist.

WITHOUT A CLEAR GAP	Your contribution becomes weak. Reviewers struggle to see novelty. Theoretical contribution stays unclear. Papers often get rejected before methodology is even evaluated.
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A RESEARCH GAP IS	A RESEARCH GAP IS NOT
✓ A limitation in current knowledge ✓ An unanswered question ✓ Conflicting evidence ✓ A new context where theories may not hold ✓ A methodological limitation ✓ A theoretical extension	✗ "Nobody has studied this topic." ✗ "Very few papers exist." ✗ "This topic interests me." ✗ "This is a trending topic." ✗ "I found one variable nobody has used."

REMEMBER	Novelty is not about studying something nobody has studied. Novelty is about generating knowledge that advances existing literature.
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The 8 Types of Research Gaps

Type	The idea	Example
1. Theoretical	Existing theories fail to explain a phenomenon completely.	The Technology Acceptance Model explains adoption. Can another theory explain continued usage better?
2. Methodological	Previous studies relied heavily on one research method.	Most studies used surveys. Can experiments or longitudinal research provide deeper insights?
3. Contextual	Findings were tested in one industry, country or setting.	AI adoption studied in healthcare. Can it be extended to education?
4. Population	Previous research focused on one population.	Studies examined Millennials. What about Gen Z?
5. Contradictory Findings	Previous studies report conflicting results.	Some studies say social media increases purchase intention. Others report no relationship. Why?
6. Practical	Academic recommendations fail to solve real-world problems.	Theory suggests one solution. Managers continue facing the same challenges.
7. Measurement	Current measurement scales have limitations.	Can an existing construct be measured differently?
8. Temporal	The world changes; theory may no longer explain today's environment.	Research before Generative AI. Research after Generative AI.

The Research Gap Decision Tree

Walk through this top to bottom for any topic you're considering.



My 5-Step Research Gap Framework

Step	What to do
1. Read recent review papers	Don't begin with individual articles. Begin with review papers; they've already summarised the field for you.
2. Map existing knowledge	Ask what we already know. Create three columns: Known, Unknown, Contradictory. Sort everything you read into one of them.
3. Find the missing conversation	Stop asking "what should I study?" Start asking "what is literature still debating?" The second question points straight at a gap.
4. Validate significance	Ask: would solving this gap advance theory, help practitioners, or change future research? If the answer is no to all three, it's probably not a publishable gap.
5. Write your gap in one paragraph	If you cannot explain your gap in 100 words, you probably don't understand it yet. Keep rewriting until you can.

3 Worked Examples

Every strong gap statement follows the same shape: what's already known, what's missing, and the sentence that turns the missing piece into a study. Here's that shape unpacked for three different gap types.

1	Contextual Gap
WHAT'S ALREADY KNOWN	Existing research has extensively examined consumer trust in AI within developed economies. There's a solid, well-cited body of work on how trust forms around AI-driven services in markets like the US, UK and Western Europe.
WHAT'S MISSING	Limited attention has been given to emerging markets, where digital infrastructure, regulation and cultural perceptions differ substantially from the contexts most existing studies were built on. Trust doesn't necessarily transfer the same way across those differences.

THE GAP STATEMENT

"Existing research has extensively examined consumer trust in AI within developed economies. However, limited attention has been given to emerging markets where digital infrastructure, regulation and cultural perceptions differ substantially. Therefore, this study investigates consumer trust in AI services within the Indian context."

WHY THIS WORKS

The gap isn't "nobody has studied India," it's a specific claim: the mechanisms known to build trust may behave differently where infrastructure and regulation are different. That's a testable reason for the study to exist, not just an unexplored postcode.

2	Methodological Gap
WHAT'S ALREADY KNOWN	Previous studies primarily used cross-sectional surveys, capturing a single snapshot of how people feel or behave at one point in time. This is the dominant method across most of the literature in this area.
WHAT'S MISSING	Cross-sectional studies cannot explain changes over time. They can tell you what correlates with what today, but not how or why attitudes and behaviours shift as circumstances change.

THE GAP STATEMENT

"Previous studies primarily used cross-sectional surveys. However, cross-sectional studies cannot explain changes over time. Therefore, this study employs longitudinal data to examine behavioural changes across multiple time periods."

WHY THIS WORKS

The gap here lives in the method itself, not the topic. Naming exactly what a cross-sectional design can't do is what justifies switching to a longitudinal one; without that limitation spelled out, "we used a different method" reads as a preference, not a contribution.

3	Contradictory Findings Gap
WHAT'S ALREADY KNOWN	Some studies report that influencer credibility significantly increases purchase intention, a fairly intuitive and widely cited finding in marketing literature.

**WHAT'S
MISSING**

Other studies report insignificant relationships between the same two variables. The literature disagrees with itself, and nobody has explained why.

THE GAP STATEMENT

Rather than asking *"Does influencer credibility matter?"*, a stronger research question becomes *"When and why does influencer credibility influence purchase intention?"*

WHY THIS WORKS

This is the most advanced gap type of the three. Instead of picking a side in the disagreement, the study reframes the question to ask what's moderating the relationship, category, platform, audience age, and so on. That reframe is what moves a paper from replication to explanation, which is exactly the distinction reviewers reward.

The Research Gap Canvas

Print this page, or fill it directly here. Work through it top to bottom for your own topic.

RESEARCH TOPIC

WHAT DO WE ALREADY KNOW?

WHAT IS STILL UNKNOWN?

WHAT KIND OF GAP IS IT?

☐ Theory	☐ Method	☐ Context	☐ Population
☐ Measurement	☐ Practical	☐ Temporal	☐ Contradictory

WHY IS THIS GAP IMPORTANT?

HOW WILL YOUR STUDY CONTRIBUTE?

5 Gap Statement Templates

Fill in the blanks with your own topic to draft a first version fast.

1

Although previous studies have examined _____, limited attention has been given to _____, highlighting the need to investigate _____.

2

Existing literature primarily focuses on _____. However, little is known about _____. This study addresses this limitation by examining _____.

3

Previous findings regarding _____ remain inconsistent. Therefore, this study investigates the conditions under which _____.

4

Most existing research has been conducted in _____. Whether these findings hold in _____ remains unclear. Accordingly, this study extends the literature by examining _____.

5

Current research explains _____. However, it does not adequately explain _____. This paper proposes _____ to bridge this gap.

10 Common Research Gap Mistakes

- ✗ Choosing a topic instead of a gap
- ✗ Confusing novelty with uniqueness
- ✗ Ignoring recent review papers
- ✗ Reading only highly cited papers
- ✗ Looking only for unexplored variables
- ✗ Weak theoretical justification
- ✗ No practical relevance
- ✗ Writing vague gap statements
- ✗ Trying to solve multiple gaps in one paper
- ✗ Starting methodology before validating the gap

Final Research Gap Checklist

Before you start writing, ask yourself:

- ✓ Can I explain the research gap in under one minute?
- ✓ Is it supported by current literature?
- ✓ Does it contribute to theory?
- ✓ Does it have practical relevance?
- ✓ Is it more than “nobody has studied this”?
- ✓ Can I justify why this study deserves to exist?
- ✓ Can reviewers immediately understand my contribution?

***The strongest research papers don't begin with impressive methods.
They begin with meaningful questions that push knowledge forward.***

About the Author

Dr Sakshi Kathuria

Associate Professor of Marketing | Research Mentor | Senior Associate Editor

Helping PhD scholars publish stronger research through practical frameworks, simplified research methodology, and evidence-based academic writing.

[@sakshi_kathuria271](#)